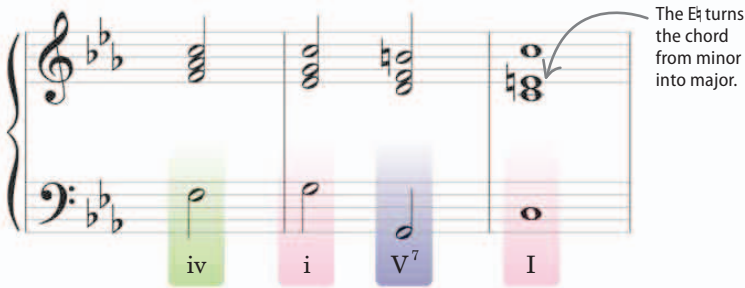


Tierce de Picardie

This is a cadence in a minor key that ends in a major chord, creating an expected change of mood. The origins of the French name are debated, but it indicates that the point of tension lies within the third of the chord moving from minor to major. Baroque music with a figured bass often leaves the decision open to the performer, whether to close with a major or minor resolution.



The E $\sharp$ turns the chord from minor into major.

△ Surprise!

The Tierce de Picardie is often found after an extended sequence of intense minor-key phrases, but even Chopin concludes many of his Nocturnes with a gentle Tierce de Picardie.

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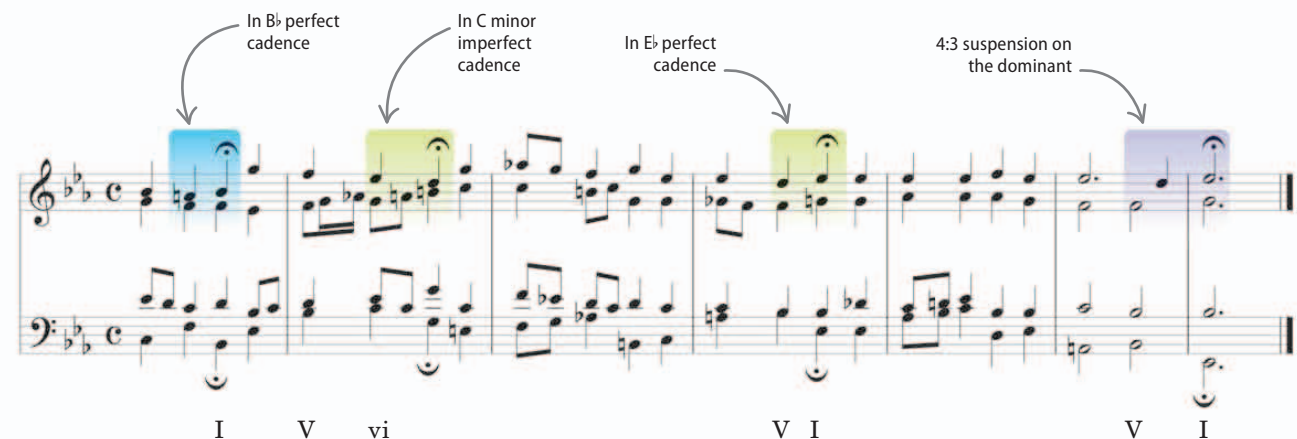
Going gently

A Tierce de Picardie need not sound false or abrupt. If the tempo of a piece is slow and the expression is sad or tender, the cadence into the minor can intensify a feeling of gentle rest. Bob Dylan's album *Modern Times* ends with "Ain't Talkin'" in E minor, which subsides and then quietly twists into E major for the last chord.



Cadences in action

The final measures of the concluding chorale to the *St John Passion* by Bach illustrate several different kinds of cadence. Bach uses each one to give a different kind of stress, or emphasis, with the last one being the strongest of all, to reinforce the sense of homecoming in E $\flat$. The shaded areas in the extract show each cadence, with the pause mark above the end of each phrase.



In B $\flat$ perfect cadence

In C minor imperfect cadence

In E $\flat$ perfect cadence

4:3 suspension on the dominant

I V vi V I V I

△ *St John Passion*

After two hours of music, telling the story of the trial and crucifixion of Jesus, the lyrics sung to this line are: "Lord Jesus Christ, hear me, I will praise your name for ever!"